

What is justice?

This question breaks down into a number of sub-questions. We can ask what it means for a **person** to be just. We can also ask what it means for an **international system** of distinct societies to be just.

Today we are going to focus on the question of what it means for an individual society — which for our purposes we can take to be a nation — to be just.

This question is sometimes called the question of **distributive justice**, because it asks about the just distribution of goods within a society at a time.

What goods are we talking about?

One category is what we might call **material goods**. These include things like food and property and income.

But these are not the only goods. Other goods include **political rights** (such as the right to vote) and **liberties** (such as the freedom to choose where one lives or whom one marries or what job one pursues). As we will see, there are others.

Our question is: what makes some societies unjust? What is required for the distribution of goods in a society to be a just distribution? We'll look at four kinds of answer to this question.

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This is enough to describe a society which most of us would agree



the property of subgroup B . Group A consolidates its power, and

At some initial time t , the members of a society are living in a state of

relative quality. But at later time $t+1$, sub-group A takes all of

enslaved the members of group B, depriving them by force of their

in the ways that members of group A direct.

political rights and liberties (such as freedom of association and the

property, and gives members of group B only the are minimized

freedom to pursue an education). By time $t+2$, group A owns all the

for survival. Members of group B are only permitted to serve group A

It is controversial that, at $t+2$, this is an unjust society.